

2026-08-30 — The Rosh HaShanah Tefillah:

מלכויות · זכרונות · שופרות

Independent review · read fresh, no exposure to the writing process · 30 August 2026

1. Overall Read

A well-structured opening installment of the three-part מחזור arc. The historical spine — משנה and גמרא baseline, then פקע דרב, then the piyutim layer — is laid out cleanly and gives the reader a real framework for orienting inside the machzor. The *Kroining Nacht* callout (Section VI) and the Reb Zusha tavern story (Section IX) are the emotional high points. The פחד/שמחה synthesis in Section VII is theologically ambitious and mostly earns its landing. Weakest zone is the middle: Section IV/V occasionally repeats itself on the "nine ברכות" and "combined with קדושת היום" points, and Section VIII feels like a hinge that hasn't quite been engineered.

2. What Works

- **The Nadvorna opening (Section II).** "הסדור במקומו, והמחזור מסדר. אָתָּה" "צריך לסדר את עצמך" is the perfect frame for a series about the machzor, and the piece uses it structurally — the whole arc keeps returning to internal preparation vs. text-mastery.
- **Section III's core-vs-piyut argument.** The move — "ask any Yid and they'll say ונתנה תוקף, but אביי ורבא never said it" — is genuinely clarifying, and the follow-up ("what do we race through fastest? the פסוקים — the actual core") is a real chiddush for most readers.
- **The Yerushalmi geography (Section V, fn6).** Galilee following ר' יוחנן, Judah following ר' עקיבא — concrete, teachable, and rare in a

public shiur on this topic.

- **The Kroining Nacht callout (Section VI, fn9).** "Yankl the tailor, Berl the shoemaker — every simple Yid gets to ascend to the כסא הכבוד" lands emotionally without sentimentality.
- **The Reb Zusha tavern story (Section IX).** Elegantly deployed to illustrate the immovability of the גזר דין — the story does the theological work the section needs.
- **The *Practical Suggestion* callout on picking one piyut.** Concrete, actionable, and consistent with the piece's overall thesis.

3. Where It's Weak or Could Be Sharper

■ **Repetition between Sections IV and V.** The "מלכויות combines with כדי שתמליכוני עליכם — point is made in IV, then re-made in V, then referenced again in VI. One clean statement with cross-references would be tighter.

■ **Section VIII (מחנה and Communal Identity).** The tension between "your personal מצוה be longer" and "you daven as a מצוה is set up but never resolved. How does a person *practically* balance both when the tzibbur is finishing? The Hillel citation at the end gestures at synthesis but doesn't deliver one.

■ **Section IX's structure.** The Dessler letter and the Reb Zusha story are both about the immovability/weight of the מצוה, but they make slightly different points (Dessler: מצוה can shift it; Zusha: once decreed, it will happen). Held next to each other without a bridge, they can read as being in mild tension.

■ **Section VI is thin (Section VI).** מצוה sets the Chaslavich story; מצוה sets the arc from מצוה זכרונות מצוה תורה ; מצוה מצוה גדולה sets one paragraph. The imbalance is noticeable.

■ **The** ■ **תוכן תוקף discussion (Section III) hedges.** The piece says the
■ piyut is "much later" and that "authorship and dating are the subject of
■ significant historical dispute" — but then never returns to what a reader should
■ *do* with the piyut. Given how much rhetorical weight the section places on the
■ piyut being non-Chazal, some direction ("say it, but know what the core is")
■ would close the loop.

4.Factual / Citation Concerns

"Multshleif Nadvorna Rebbe" (fn1). The spelling — apparently a

transliteration heard by ear — should be verified. Standard English

spellings for Nadvorna sub-branches include *Mishkoltz, Bania, Zutchka*.

If "Multshleif" is meant to be Miskolc/Mishkoltz, the file should say so; if

it's a distinct branch, it needs confirming.

" **רבי חיים שמואל לווין (fn11).** The name as spelled is not one I can

identify with confidence — possibly Rav Chaim Shmuel *Lopian, Levovitz,*

or a different figure. The fn itself acknowledges no sefer/page. Worth

nailing down before print.

Rav's dating (fn8). "First-generation Amora, c. 175–247 CE" — the

birth year is conventionally given as c. 175 but some sources have c. 155

or 180; 247 as the death year is standard. Fine as-is but worth confirming.

" **מקלע דרב** as a technical term (fn8). The phrase is used in the

piece as if it were a fixed	מקלע דרב coinage. The term does appear in later
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halachic literature for Rav's	מקלע דרב establishments, but a reader may be
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surprised to find it not straightforwardly in the Gemara — a brief sourcing

note in the fn would help.

ציטאציע (fn14). The fn honestly notes the specific siman was

not cited in the shiur and suggests	מקצ"ז Worth checking before print
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— the	מנהג	מחשלות מנות	מנהג השנה discussed by several early
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acharonim and getting the right one matters.

Zohar citation (fn16). "דף ק"א ע"א (פרשת אמור)"	—זוהר חלק ג this
daf reference should be verified; the	application to עמי אנכי יושבת
communal davening on the Yamim Nora'im is a well-known Zohar passage	
but the exact location varies by edition.	

5.Small Polish Suggestions

- Section I is very short (one paragraph). Either fold it into the Section II opening or expand — currently it reads as a preamble to a preamble.
- Section III: "spoiler — not וַיִּתְּנָהּ תִּקְוָה, however moving it is" in the lead is good; the phrasing "and rightfully so" in the body ("*Ask any Yid... And rightfully so*") slightly undercuts the argument the section is about to make. Consider trimming.
- Section IV: "*Ten ברכות in principle — but the גמרא rules...*" — the "in principle" is doing a lot of work here; a clause explaining *why* ten would have been the count would help a lay reader.
- Section V, on Rav's compositions: the bulleted list of introductions is helpful, but the paragraph immediately after ("*Rav's introductions became fixed liturgy...*") should note that this is the *same* עלינו that closes every davening — the piece says it, but almost as an aside; it's actually a striking historical fact worth landing.
- Section VII, *Dimension of פחד*: "רבי חיים שמואל לווית" — if this name is uncertain (see fn concern above), consider paraphrasing without attribution rather than misnaming.

- Section IX callout: "*peasants decided to beat Reb Zusha three times*" reads oddly precise for a decision made by drunks. Consider "*gave Reb Zusha a beating*" and letting the "three times" emerge in Reb Zusha's punchline.
- Practical Takeaways: "*the mishloach manos per the פרי' חדש*" — the שמחה side and the פחד side get listed as balanced items, but the mishloach manos is quite obscure while the תלויים ועומדים is core; consider swapping in something more central to the שמחה side (e.g., בגדי לבן, חדות ה' היא מעוזכם).
- Colophon still reads "First of three shiurim" — good; but the header meta and the lead say the same thing. One placement would suffice.

6. Bottom Line

Yes — a strong opening to the machzor arc, anchored by the Nadvorna frame and the core-vs-piyut chiddush; tighten the IV/V repetition, beef up the רבי חיים section, and verify the "Multshleif Nadvorna" and "ואל לויט" attributions before print.

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